

Overview: Now-Next Boards

Now-Next boards provide a simple, powerful visual framework for showing pupils what is happening right now and what comes immediately after. By making the sequence of activities visible and concrete, they dramatically reduce the anxiety that comes from uncertainty about transitions. For pupils who struggle with change, seeing "what comes next" transforms an unpredictable experience into a manageable one.

When to Use This Strategy

- Asks repeatedly "What are we doing next?" or "When is break?"
- Becomes visibly anxious as activities near completion
- Resists stopping current activities even when prompted
- Needs excessive reassurance about upcoming changes
- Meltdowns or shutdowns during transition periods

Step-by-Step Guide

1 Create the basic board

Make a simple board with two clearly labelled sections: NOW on the left and NEXT on the right. Use A4 or A3 card, with Velcro strips for attaching cards, or use a whiteboard with Post-it notes.

Tip: Laminate the board for durability, but don't wait for perfect resources - Post-it notes work immediately.

2 Prepare activity cards

Create small cards for common activities: Maths, English, Reading, Writing, Break, Lunch, PE, Assembly, Pack up, Home time. Use words, pictures/symbols, or both depending on the pupil's needs.

Teacher says: "These cards show what we're doing. Let's look at them together."

Tip: Start with 8-10 cards covering your most frequent activities. Add more as needed.

3 Position the board accessibly

Place the board where the pupil can see it from their seat without asking permission or standing up. On their desk is ideal for individual boards; at the front for whole-class boards.

Tip: If the pupil needs to ask to see the board, half the benefit is lost.

4 Introduce the system explicitly

Teach the pupil what the board means and how to use it. Show them how NOW tells them what to do right now, and NEXT shows what is coming. Practice reading the board together.

Teacher says: "This is your Now-Next board. NOW tells you what we're doing right now. NEXT shows what comes after. You can look at it whenever you want to know what's happening."

5 Update BEFORE transitions

Always move the cards before you announce a change. The pupil sees the update, processes the upcoming change, and is prepared before it happens. This is the most critical step.

Teacher says: "Watch me update your board. See? NEXT is changing to Reading. That's what we're doing after this."

Tip: Give a verbal cue as you update so the pupil notices the change.

6 Build the checking habit

When the pupil asks what's happening, redirect them to the board instead of answering verbally. This builds independence and makes the board their go-to resource.

Teacher says: "Great question. Check your board - what does NEXT say?"

7 Add THEN when ready (optional)

Once the pupil is confident with Now-Next, add a THEN section for longer sequences if needed. This shows one more step into the future. Only add this if the pupil needs to see further ahead.

Teacher says: "I've added THEN to your board. Now you can see even further ahead: NOW, then NEXT, then THEN."

Tip: Not all pupils need THEN. Some find it overwhelming. Follow the pupil's lead.

English Example: Managing a writing lesson with breaks

Year 5 pupil becomes anxious during extended writing, constantly asking when they can stop. Working at age-appropriate level but struggles with uncertainty about timing.

Set up the board before the lesson

Teacher: Places NOW card showing "Writing" and NEXT card showing "Brain break". Shows the pupil: "Look, writing now, then a brain break."

Pupil: Sees the sequence. Knows a break is coming.

Remind during the task

Teacher: When pupil asks "When can I stop?", points to the board: "Check your Now-Next. What comes after writing?"

Pupil: Looks at board. Sees "Brain break" in NEXT. Continues writing with less anxiety.

Update before the transition

Teacher: Before announcing the break, updates the board: NOW becomes "Brain break", NEXT becomes "More writing". Says: "Watch me change your board. Break time is moving to NOW."

Pupil: Sees the change before it happens. Transitions smoothly to break.

Continue the pattern

Teacher: Repeats the update-before-change pattern throughout the lesson. Each transition is visible before it is announced.

Pupil: Checks board independently. Transitions become predictable and manageable.

Maths Example: Supporting transitions between lesson phases

Year 7 pupil has meltdowns when asked to stop one activity and start another unexpectedly.

Show the lesson structure

Teacher: At lesson start, shows Now-Next board: NOW is "Starter activity", NEXT is "Learning new method". Says: "Here's what we're doing. I'll update this before we change."

Pupil: Sees the plan. Knows what to expect.

Give advance warning via the board

Teacher: Two minutes before the transition, updates NEXT to confirm it. Says quietly: "Look at your board. NEXT is coming soon. Two more minutes on the starter."

Pupil: Sees the upcoming change. Has time to prepare mentally.

Make the transition

Teacher: Moves "Learning new method" to NOW, adds "Practice questions" to NEXT. Says: "Board is updated. We're moving to NOW - learning the new method."

Pupil: Sees the change happen on the board first. Transitions without distress.

Use THEN for the full lesson

Teacher: Adds THEN section showing "Plenary" so pupil can see three steps ahead throughout the lesson.

Pupil: Checks board periodically. Knows exactly where they are in the lesson.

Science Example: Managing a practical lesson with multiple phases

Year 8 pupil becomes very anxious during practicals because the sequence of activities is unpredictable. Working at KS2 level and needs high predictability.

Set up detailed Now-Next-Then

Teacher: Creates board with three sections. NOW: "Safety talk", NEXT: "Collect equipment", THEN: "Do experiment". Shows pupil at start of lesson.

Pupil: Sees the full sequence of the practical. Anxiety reduced because the unknown becomes known.

Update as each phase completes

Teacher: After safety talk, shifts cards: NOW becomes "Collect equipment", NEXT becomes "Do experiment", THEN becomes "Write up". Says: "Watch me update - we're moving on."

Pupil: Sees progress through the lesson visually. Knows exactly what stage they are at.

Handle an unexpected change

Teacher: Equipment issue means skipping a step. Updates board first: "I need to change our plan. Watch your board - I'm updating it now." Changes cards to show new sequence.

Pupil: Sees the change on the board before it affects them. Can process the unexpected change because it is made visible.

End with pack-up sequence

Teacher: Final update shows NOW: "Pack up", NEXT: "Plenary", THEN: "Home time". Guides through final transitions using the board.

Pupil: Completes lesson knowing exactly what remains. Transitions to end of lesson smoothly.